

Exploring Mars

Spacecraft have flown past Mars, orbited it, and landed on its surface. One day, we may even build a base on Mars. It may be cold, barren, and dusty, but it's full of possibilities.

Why study Mars?

At some point in its history, life may have existed on Mars. Although it's about half the size of Earth, it has clouds, weather patterns, and polar icecaps – once it even had active volcanoes. Learning about Mars may help us to understand our own planet.



On the barren surface of Mars, the robotic *Sojourner* rover examines a rock later nicknamed "Yogi".

Seeing red

The landing craft that visited Mars took lots of pictures of its surface. These show a layer of soil that is rich in iron, which gives Mars its red colour – like rusty iron on Earth.

Looking at Mars

There have been a number of missions to Mars.



In 1971, two spacecraft, *Mars 2* and *Mars 3*, got to Mars, but their landers failed to operate.



In 1976, two spacecraft, the *Viking* landers, tested for signs of life.



In 1996, *Mars Global Surveyor* was launched. It completed its first mission, but later lost contact.



In 1997, *Pathfinder* touched down, releasing a small rover called *Sojourner*.



In 1999, the *Mars Polar Lander* proved unsuccessful.

